

HTML Text Formatting Elements

HTML text-formatting elements are used to change the appearance of text or indicate its meaning and importance. They can represent strong importance, emphasis, highlighted content, inserted or deleted text, scientific formulas, quotations, abbreviations, and computer code.

1. `<b>` — Bold Text

The `<b>` element displays text in bold without indicating additional importance.

```
<p>This course covers <b>HTML, CSS and JavaScript</b>.</p>
```

Output: This course covers **HTML, CSS and JavaScript**.

Use `<b>` when attention is required visually but the text does not carry special importance.

2. `<strong>` — Important Text

The `<strong>` element identifies text with strong importance. Browsers normally display it in bold.

```
<p><strong>Warning:</strong> Submit the form before leaving.</p>
```

Output: Warning: Submit the form before leaving.

`<b>` versus `<strong>`

<code></code>	<code></code>
Makes text visually bold	Indicates strong importance
Mainly presentational	Provides semantic meaning
Screen readers may treat it as normal text	Assistive technologies may emphasize it

3. `<i>` — Alternate Voice or Italic Text

The `<i>` element normally displays text in italic. It is suitable for technical terms, foreign expressions, thoughts, and alternative voices.

```
<p>The term <i>responsive design</i> is used in web development.</p>
```

4. `<em>` — Emphasized Text

The `<em>` element adds semantic emphasis. Browsers normally display it in italic.

```
<p>You <em>must</em> submit the assignment today.</p>
```

The emphasized word changes the intended stress of the sentence.

`<i>` versus `<em>`

<code><i></code>	<code></code>
Represents an alternate voice or term	Represents verbal emphasis
Usually displayed in italic	Usually displayed in italic
Does not necessarily indicate stress	Provides semantic importance

5. `<mark>` — Highlighted Text

The `<mark>` element highlights text that is relevant in the current context.

```
<p>Registration closes on <mark>10 September 2026</mark>.</p>
```

Browsers normally display marked text with a yellow background.

6. `<small>` — Smaller or Secondary Text

The `<small>` element represents side comments, disclaimers, legal text, or copyright information. Browsers normally display it in a smaller font.

```
<p>  
  Course fee: ₹5,000  
  <small>Taxes may apply.</small>  
</p>
```

Another example:

```
<footer>  
  <small>&copy; 2026 ABC University</small>  
</footer>
```

7. `<del>` — Deleted Text

The `<del>` element represents text that has been removed from a document. Browsers normally display it with a line through it.

```
<p>  
  Original fee:  
  <del>₹5,000</del>  
</p>
```

The `datetime` attribute can record when the content was deleted:

```
<p>
  Fee:
  <del datetime="2026-08-20">₹5,000</del>
</p>
```

8. `<ins>` — Inserted Text

The `<ins>` element represents newly added content. Browsers normally display it with an underline.

```
<p>
  Updated fee:
  <ins>₹3,500</ins>
</p>
```

`<del>` and `<ins>` can show a modification:

```
<p>
  Course fee:
  <del>₹5,000</del>
  <ins>₹3,500</ins>
</p>
```

9. `<sub>` — Subscript Text

The `<sub>` element displays text below the normal baseline. It is commonly used in chemical formulas and mathematical notation.

```
<p>Water: H<sub>2</sub>O</p>
<p>Carbon dioxide: CO<sub>2</sub></p>
```

Output:

- H₂O
 - CO₂
-

10. `<sup>` — Superscript Text

The `<sup>` element displays text above the normal baseline. It is used for exponents, ordinal indicators, and footnote references.

```
<p>Equation: x<sup>2</sup> + y<sup>2</sup></p>
<p>Einstein's equation: E = mc<sup>2</sup></p>
<p>Date: 1<sup>st</sup> September</p>
```

11. `<u>` — Annotated Text

The `<u>` element represents text with a non-textual annotation. Browsers generally underline it.

```
<p>The word <u>recieve</u> is incorrectly spelled.</p>
```

Because users often interpret underlined text as a hyperlink, avoid using `<u>` only for visual decoration. CSS is usually more suitable for decorative underlining.

```
<p style="text-decoration: underline;">
  Underlined using CSS
</p>
```

12. `<s>` — No Longer Accurate Text

The `<s>` element represents information that is no longer accurate or relevant.

```
<p>
  Regular price: <s>₹2,000</s>
  Offer price: ₹1,500
</p>
```

`<s>` versus `<del>`

- `<s>` indicates information that is no longer accurate.
 - `<del>` records content deleted during document editing.
-

13. `<br>` — Line Break

The `<br>` element starts the following content on a new line without creating a new paragraph.

```
<p>
  Ashima Sharma<br>
  Department of Computer Science<br>
  ABC University
</p>
```

`<br>` is a void element and does not require a closing tag.

Use separate `<p>` elements for different paragraphs rather than using repeated `<br>` elements to create spacing.

14. `<hr>` — Thematic Break

The `<hr>` element represents a thematic change or separation between sections.

```
<h2>Course Description</h2>
<p>This section explains the course.</p>

<hr>

<h2>Assessment</h2>
<p>This section explains the assessment scheme.</p>
```

Browsers normally display it as a horizontal line.

15. `<abbr>` — Abbreviation

The `<abbr>` element represents an abbreviation or acronym. The `title` attribute provides its full form.

```
<p>
  <abbr title="HyperText Markup Language">HTML</abbr>
  is used to structure webpages.
</p>
```

When the user places the pointer over `HTML`, the browser may display its full form.

16. `<q>` — Inline Quotation

The `<q>` element represents a short quotation within a paragraph. Browsers normally add quotation marks automatically.

```
<p>
  The instructor said,
  <q>Practice HTML every day.</q>
</p>
```

A source URL can be specified using `cite`:

```
<p>
  The guide states,
  <q cite="https://example.com/html-guide">
    Semantic HTML improves document structure.
  </q>
</p>
```

17. `<blockquote>` — Block Quotation

The `<blockquote>` element represents a longer quotation displayed as a separate block.

```
<blockquote cite="https://example.com/article">
  Web accessibility ensures that websites can be used
  by people with different abilities and assistive technologies.
</blockquote>
```

Use `<q>` for short inline quotations and `<blockquote>` for longer, separate quotations.

18. `<cite>` — Title of a Creative Work

The `<cite>` element represents the title of a creative work, such as a book, research paper, film, painting, or song.

```
<p>
  <cite>Introduction to Web Development</cite>
  was written for beginner programmers.
</p>
```

It should not normally be used only to mark a person's name.

19. `<code>` — Computer Code

The `<code>` element represents a short fragment of computer code.

```
<p>
  Use the <code>&lt;h1&gt;</code> element for the main heading.
</p>
```

HTML entities are used so the browser displays `<h1>` as text instead of interpreting it as an HTML element.

For a multi-line code block, combine `<pre>` and `<code>`:

```
<pre><code>&lt;h1&gt;Welcome&lt;/h1&gt;
&lt;p&gt;This is a webpage.&lt;/p&gt;</code></pre>
```

20. `<pre>` — Preformatted Text

The `<pre>` element preserves spaces and line breaks exactly as written in the source code.

```
<pre>
Name:      Ashima
Department: Computer Science
Course:    HTML
</pre>
```

It is commonly used for:

- Code blocks
 - Text diagrams
 - Tabular plain text
 - Content requiring preserved spacing
-

21. `<kbd>` — Keyboard Input

The `<kbd>` element represents keyboard input or commands entered by a user.

```
<p>
  Press <kbd>Ctrl</kbd> + <kbd>S</kbd>
  to save the file.
</p>
```

22. `<samp>` — Sample Program Output

The `<samp>` element represents output generated by a computer program.

```
<p>
  Program output:
  <samp>Registration successful</samp>
</p>
```

23. `<var>` — Variable

The `<var>` element represents a variable in mathematics or programming.

```
<p>
  The area of a rectangle is
  <var>length</var> × <var>width</var>.
</p>
```

24. `<bdo>` — Bidirectional Override

The `<bdo>` element overrides the normal direction of text.

```
<p>
  <bdo dir="rtl">This text is displayed from right to left.</bdo>
</p>
```

Common `dir` values are:

- `ltr`: left to right
- `rtl`: right to left

25. `<span>` — Inline Container

The `<span>` element groups inline text so that CSS or JavaScript can be applied to it. It does not carry special semantic meaning.

```
<p>
  The assignment status is
  <span style="color: green; font-weight: bold;">
    Completed
  </span>.
</p>
```

Complete Text-Formatting Webpage

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport"
    content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">

  <title>HTML Text Formatting</title>
</head>
<body>

  <h1>HTML Text Formatting Examples</h1>

  <p>This is <b>bold text</b>.</p>

  <p>This is <strong>important text</strong>.</p>

  <p>This is an <i>alternative term</i>.</p>

  <p>This is <em>emphasized text</em>.</p>

  <p>This is <mark>highlighted text</mark>.</p>

  <p>This is <small>secondary information</small>.</p>

  <p>
    Course fee:
    <del>₹5,000</del>
    <ins>₹3,500</ins>
  </p>

  <p>
    Chemical formulas:
    H<sub>2</sub>O and CO<sub>2</sub>
  </p>

  <p>
    Mathematical expression:
    x<sup>2</sup> + y<sup>2</sup>
  </p>

  <p>
```

```
<abbr title="HyperText Markup Language">HTML</abbr>
structures webpages.
</p>

<p>
  Press <kbd>Ctrl</kbd> + <kbd>S</kbd>
  to save the file.
</p>

<p>
  Use the <code>&lt;p&gt;</code> element
  to create a paragraph.
</p>

<p>
  The instructor said,
  <q>Practice improves coding skills.</q>
</p>

<blockquote>
  Web development combines structure, presentation
  and interactivity to create useful digital experiences.
</blockquote>

<p>
  Assignment status:
  <span style="color: green; font-weight: bold;">
    Completed
  </span>
</p>

<hr>

<small>&copy; 2026 Web Development Course</small>

</body>
</html>
```